Field Notes and Photo Documentation

While participating in the experience, I took field notes of observations related to the setting/environment, guide's interpretation, and tourist interaction with the microentrepreneur leading the experience. Field notes consisted of the logistics of the experience, highlighted wildlife/ecological features discussed throughout, and types of questions tourists asked throughout the experience. Other observations made during the field visit noted how the microentrepreneur explained certain environmental conservation topics and the logistics of how the experience was set up (i.e. safety expectations, equipment preparations, etc.).

As well as written notes, I took several pictures of my surroundings, equipment and places we visited during the tour. Pictures allow me to show what kinds of landscapes people see while on the tour and exemplify the small group experience. Pictures can show people the type of environment the tourism activity is happening in and help the viewer have a clearer understanding of what the microentrepreneur does. Photos were also used to demonstrate the natural resources that allow nature-based tourism to exist in Naples Florida.

Mangrove Kayak Environment

Caption example:

Figure 1. Mangrove tunnel ecosystem explored during the kayak eco-tour experience near Naples, Florida.

Launch Area / Tour Starting Point

Caption example:

Figure 2. Launch location where the tour guide prepared equipment and provided the safety briefing before the eco-tour.

Wildlife and Ecosystem Observations

Caption example:

Figure 3. Mangrove ecosystem habitat observed during the eco-tour, demonstrating the biodiversity supported by coastal mangrove forests.

Kayak Equipment and Small Group Experience

Caption example:

Figure 4. Small group format used for the guided eco-tour, allowing the guide to provide interpretation of the mangrove ecosystem.

Participant Observation of Microentrepreneurial Tourism Experience

Description of the Microentrepreneur and the Experience

For this assignment I booked a tourism experience offered by a local micro-business owner located in Naples, Florida. The booked activity was a kayak eco-tour guided through the mangrove estuaries found near the Ten Thousand Islands which was offered by a privately owned small independent eco-tour company. The eco-tours they provide place emphasis on wildlife watching, environmental education and seeing the mangrove estuaries found only in Southwest Florida.

The tour lasted approximately two hours. Our tour began outside of Naples near the coast at a boat launching station. After a short safety/information session about the surrounding ecosystem we boarded our kayaks. We navigated through tunnels of mangroves and shallow estuary waters. Our guide informed us about many different facts on the ecosystem. Mangrove trees help prevent destruction along the coast. Mangroves provide homes for fish, birds, and sea life. They also assist in helping shorelines stay together which can help protect coastal populations (“Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission”, 2022).

On our tour we were able to see different wildlife that interact with the mangrove ecosystem including birds and fish. Our tour guide also educated us on how Naples's area tourism has started to include more nature-based tourism. Kayaking, wildlife viewing, and eco tours are just some examples of how tourists can do more than just lay on the beach. Nature based tourism can help benefit Florida's tourism economy and help with sustainability efforts (Visit Florida, 2023). This tour allowed people who visited the area to learn about the outdoors of Southwest Florida and be able to partake in an outdoor activity.

Description and Critique of the Booking Process

Booking this experience was easy and seamless. This tour was posted on a tourism booking website. There were pictures of the experience, descriptions, and reviews from people who have previously booked the experience. You could see how long the tour was and what equipment you would be provided. They gave the meeting location.

Once you choose your desired date and time you had to fill out your payment information and book your reservation. I received an email confirmation within a few minutes of booking. It had directions to where you meet for lunch as well as what to bring with you (water, sunscreen, clothes to swim in etc.). This experience was priced around $60 per person. I thought this was fairly priced since they gave you all equipment and included an informative tour.

The booking process overall was successful, however there were a couple things I thought could be improved upon. Such as adding more details to where the meeting place was because it was hard to find if you aren't familiar with the area. Also add more description to the tour about what the physical demands are so you know what you are getting into and if you feel you can complete the activity. Including more information about helping conserve the environment while experiencing their tour may also attract visitors who want to participate in sustainable tourism.

Salient Assets of the Microentrepreneur

There were several assets exhibited by the guide leading our eco-tour. The most valuable asset I noticed was extensive knowledge about the area ecosystem. Our guide taught us about mangrove forests, tidal movement, and wildlife living habitats. How each of these helped keep coastal ecosystems healthy. Mangrove ecosystems are considered some of Florida's most productive ecosystems (Florida Department of Environmental Protection, 2021).

One other key asset was the guide's ability to educate participants while they experienced the tour. Instead of just leading people through the mangroves, our tour educated guests on wildlife, conservation, and environmental benefits of the area. There are many resources that outline educational interpretation as a crucial element to quality experiences in nature-based tourism (Ham & Weiler, 2017).

We had access to rare natural sites (mangrove tunnels, shallow water channels that can only be navigated by our guide) that most tourists do not know about or cannot access without a local

guide with specialized knowledge or transportation. Because of this microentrepreneurs are able to offer something different than large tourism companies. Small groups also helped keep the experience interactive and personal.

Pressing Needs of the Microentrepreneur

Although this experience is fairly strong in many aspects, like most small tourism businesses there are several areas where the microentrepreneur could use some support. One clear need is more visibility on marketing channels. The experience is listed on online booking sites, but many tourists visiting Naples may not know about smaller scale eco-tour operations like this compared to larger companies within the tourism industry. Building stronger ties with hotels locally, visitor centers, or tourism relations groups could improve knowledge of these experiences.

Seasonal tourism ebbs and flows pose another issue. Naples primarily sees winter tourism from travelers coming from colder climates in the United States. Summer through early fall there tends to be less desire to travel because of the hot weather and hurricane season. Seasonality can cause difficulties for small tourism business owners looking to make year-round income (Gössling, Scott, & Hall, 2020).

The other downside to being a microentrepreneur is having limited financial and manpower resources. Running a small tourism experience takes a lot of hands-on work, from leading the experience itself to upkeep of equipment, marketing the experience and taking bookings. Outside assistance with marketing or finding business partners could help alleviate some work by allowing the microentrepreneur to offer more experience.

Accompaniment Plan for the Next 12 Months

If I were able to accompany this microentrepreneur for the course of one year, I would aim to learn more about his business while helping him brainstorm additional opportunities to grow and sustain his business. Observation and informal chatting after tours would allow me to see first-hand how his business operates and may differ throughout the seasons.

Actively seeking connections with local hotels, visitor centers, or outdoor recreation and environmental organizations would allow this eco-tour opportunity to be shared with visitors looking to participate in these activities. Working with environmental organizations may also allow for the business to enhance their educational element of tours.

I would also accompany the microentrepreneur by helping him think of ways to diversify tourism opportunities beyond kayak tours. This may include sunset kayak tours as noted by the microentrepreneur, photography tours with wildlife, or mangrove education lessons. Tourism diversification allows micro-entrepreneurs to rely less on one tourism opportunity while allowing them to attract new visitors (Gössling et al., 2020).

Accompaniment through constant observation, communication, and collaboration would allow me to learn from the micro-entrepreneur while he continues running his business as he knows best. Participating means we can learn from locals while helping them grow their businesses.

References

Florida Department of Environmental Protection. (2021). *Mangrove ecosystems of Florida*. https://floridadep.gov

Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission. (2022). *Mangroves and coastal ecosystems*. https://myfwc.com

Gössling, S., Scott, D., & Hall, C. M. (2020). *Pandemics, tourism and global change: A rapid assessment of COVID-19*. Journal of Sustainable Tourism, 29(1), 1-20.

Ham, S., & Weiler, B. (2017). *Interpretation as the center of the visitor experience*. Journal of Interpretation Research, 22(2), 9-21.

Visit Florida. (2023). *Florida tourism industry overview*. https://www.visitflorida.org